

SHOWCASING VISION 2015

According to Chief Minister Pawan Chamling, "My vision for Sikkim includes the creation of a peaceful State. Sikkim with its pluralistic polity has made tremendous achievements in ensuring a good quality of life for its people. To this end, I always work to ensure that Sikkim remains a peaceful State. I realise that this is a tall task as we are not only a pluralistic society but also surrounded by India's neighbours, including Bhutan, Nepal and China. We have ensured that peace prevails on our international border as also among our ethnic groups, including Nepalis, Lepchas and Bhutias. My stress is on conserving the rich environmental resources that nature has given us. I want to make Sikkim the most developed State in India."

The efforts of Mr Chamling to make Sikkim one of the best states of India by promoting balanced and sustainable growth involves plans to

- Raise the per capita income of the people of the State to Rs one lakh
- Make Sikkim a zero-poverty State
- Make Sikkim fully literate
- To make it as a land of opportunity
- To make Sikkim the principal tourism destination in South and South-East Asia
- Make Sikkim a pollution and disease-free State
- Make it the best welfare State in the country
- Make it a producer State
- Make it the best performing State
- Make it the most competitive and efficient mountain economy.

A review of how his untiring efforts have translated in the hill state.

Rural Development: Sikkim allocates 70 per cent of the total Plan budget for the development of rural areas. It is among the few States in the country that devolve maximum administrative and financial powers to Panchayati Raj institutions. There is a public library in each panchayat unit.

Ecology: Sikkim ranks first in the field of environmental protection and development. It is among the first States to call for public participation in programmes such as Avenue Plantation, Green Road, Green Villages and Towns.

The State maintains environmental and ecological balance by prohibiting deforestation, grazing in reserve forest land and

killing of wild animals and birds. The Sikkim Democratic Front (SDF) government is the first State government to ban the use of non-biodegradable substances like plastic.

Tourism: Living up to its billing as one of the most peaceful states in the nation, tourism footfall in Sikkim is growing by leaps and bounds as the latest figures point out.

Officials recorded ten per cent growth of tourists' inflow in this Himalayan state this year with around 3.27 lakh tourists visiting Sikkim till October this year as against 3.5 lakh in 2007.

Per Capita Growth: The per capita gross domestic product recorded over three-fold increase from a mere Rs 8,457 in 1993-94 to Rs 29,808 in 2005-06. This means Sikkim recorded a 3.5-fold increase in the per-capita income of each Sikkimese.

Among the 28 States and seven union territories in the country Sikkim has the fifth-highest growth rate in per capita income and 14th-highest per capita income. The latest report of the Reserve Bank of India on the State Finances — a study of Budget 2006-07 — mentions that Sikkim is the State which devotes the highest share of 31.3 per cent of its budget to the social sector.

The percentage of population below poverty line has gone down steadily after recording a sharp jump in 1993-94. The percentage of households below poverty line has gone down drastically to 19.2 per cent

Welfare measures: Rice is provided at a subsidised rate of Rs.4 a kilogram to Below Poverty Line (BPL) families and 35 kg of rice is provided to the poorest of the poor free of cost.

Sikkim is among the first States to provide free liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) connections and stoves to BPL families. Chamling himself goes from door to door to distribute benefits through "Janata Mela".

Women's empowerment: Sikkim is the first State to extend all government benefits in the name of the mother of a family. In Sikkim it is mandatory to write the names of both father and mother in all official documents.

It is the first State that has made it a legal requirement to have the consent of both the husband and the wife while purchasing immovable property.

The State encourages the education of girl children by adopting the "Small Family Scheme" and by opening savings accounts in the names of school-going girls. The State has been widely commended for maintaining gender equality and for the absence of gender-related violence.

To enable the women to play a greater role in the Panchayati Raj Institution and also in the Government administration, 40 per cent seats have been reserved in Panchayats and 30 per cent seats in Government jobs for women. On June 10 2008, government has passed a landmark Bill in the State